Madras, 21 February 1854

RUGGED JOURNEYS

By the 1880s, the railways had become an integral part of the Indian topography. Lines had been built across major parts of the subcontinent and where the main line did not go, the narrow and metre gauge had taken the lead to spread the railway culture. Such widespread local lines led to large-scale adventures, with some of them documented in history books, travel diaries and autobiographies. The travel diary of geologist Valentine Ball is one such record. His book *Jungle Life of India; or, The Journeys and Journals of an Indian Geologist* (published circa 1880) has notes on experiences of his train journeys as he travelled across the subcontinent.

The finding of coal by Major Sandeman in 1874 near Derajat (today in central Pakistan) required an officer of the Geological Survey of India to be sent for inspection. Here is an excerpt from officer Ball's account.

> The climate of the Derajat in July enjoys a somewhat evil reputation, and the Government of India most considerately declined to order any geologist on this mission, but granted permission to whoever might be selected by the Superintendent of the Survey to proceed or not at his own risk. The offer being made to me was gladly accepted, as an opportunity of visiting such remote regions, beyond the British frontier, was not likely to recur, and the trip promised to be one of great interest… I therefore immediately made my preparations, and left Calcutta by train for Multan on the night of the 3rd of July. By travelling straight through, I reached Lahore at noon on the 6th. As the train for Multan does not leave until the evening, on account of the excessive heat by day, I employed the time at my disposal in visiting the city of Lahore and its neighbourhood. I shall not, however, here pause to describe what I saw, but continue the account of my journey. At 5.30 p.m. the train left for Multan. The carriages on this line—very different in construction from those in which I had come through from Calcutta to Lahore with great comfort—were divided into narrow compartments, and heavily cushioned, being apparently cunningly devised to intensify the sufferings of passengers. A slow rate of progression, frequent and long stoppages, and an abundance of flying sand, proved to be causes of further discomfort and irritation. I, the only European passenger in the train, passed a terrible night, and the natives seemed to suffer almost as much, as at every station the cries for water were unceasing. [60]

BUYING ELEPHANTS FROM EAST INDIA RAILWAY

During one such journey, Ball writes how he was delayed for the purchase of some elephants on behalf of the government, describing them in detail and how they proved to be an excellent investment.